in reality, the destroyed prison colony of aliens from outer space, but I'm not convinced. In our defence of the Internet, it became clear, years ago, that Scientology was among the great enemies of the freedom it might make possible. The Internet is, by its true nature, a censorship-free zone. Not good for those in the Hubbard cupboard, who see censorship, concealment and revelation (for a fee) as the very reason for their existence.

The church has fostered a large network of manipulation. It has used legal processes and illegal harassment to pursue newspapers, ex-members and many others, even while it remains subject to an FBI investigation itself. Sinisterly, the church considers its religious teachings to be copyrighted trade secrets. Later, WikiLeaks blew the whistle on them by publishing a collection of these nonsense teachings, complete with 'Copyright 1966, by L. Ron Hubbard, All Rights Reserved' emblazoned on each page: 'The state of Clear is terrific. We have waited on this state for a very long time. When an individual goes Clear, he goes over a bump.' If you'll forgive the pun, confronting these nutters brought me clarity. The fight against the church is far more than the Net versus a bunch of wackos with too much money. It is about the corporate suppression of the Internet and free speech. It is about intellectual property and the meaning of personal expression and the principle of unfettered access. The year of my Australian trial I wrote about all this, and of how the precedents set by the Church of Scientology today would prove to be useful weapons for corporate tyranny tomorrow. I'd always been an activist in my bones, but back then all my time, when not with my son, was spent building what you might call global platforms for local protest. We demonstrated outside the Church of Scientology, for instance, on Flinders Street, handing out leaflets while also opposing, on mailing lists and message boards, their every effort to suppress free speech.

It was a journey from the local to the global and back again. My favourite kind of journey.